

THE CAPABILITY FORMATION FIELD KIT

Read Your Position. Know Your Exposure.

A self-diagnostic built from eighteen years inside the rooms where talent decisions get made.

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Meant to be used, not just read.



Thank you for buying the Field Kit. Everything in it comes from eighteen years inside the rooms where talent decisions get made, rebuilt as a diagnostic you can run on yourself in one sitting. It is meant to be used, not just read, and it is meant to be rerun: your position is a moving fact, and this kit is how you track it.

Here is what to do first. Block ninety minutes. Complete Section 1 in one pass, scoring against the last ninety days of your actual working life and writing the evidence line under every statement. Then place yourself in Section 2, run the calibration in Section 3, and only then face what standing still is taking from you and write your self-read. The order matters: the calibration exists to correct the scores before you build anything on them.

One framing note before you begin. AI is the disruption with today's headlines, and it will not be the last one. This diagnostic measures your position against the category of disruption, not the current episode. That is why the last section turns it into a quarterly habit.

Score honestly. The number is a map of where you stand, not a measure of what you are worth.

Temidayo Afonja

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Stay connected

- The digital audit and the essays: temidayoafonja.com
- The full framework: The Capability Audit, on Kindle and paperback
- The essays, every Monday: temidayoafonja.substack.com

P.S. When a number moves at your next rescore, tell me. Moved numbers are the stories I follow closest, and people who bring them get first notice when a session opens.



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Score

The twelve statements, with an evidence line under every score

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Before you start

Block ninety minutes and work the sections in order. Score first, calibrate before you trust the numbers, and leave the self-read for last. Everything is typeable: fill it in on screen or print it and write.

The order matters. Calibration exists to correct the scores before you build anything on them.



SECTION 1

Score

Twelve statements, scored 1 (strongly disagree) to 5 (strongly agree), against the last ninety days of your actual working life. Not the life you intend to start living next quarter.



Part One: Density

Learning velocity. Six statements, out of 30.



The evidence protocol: under each score, write the evidence from the last ninety days. Every score, in both directions. A 4 or 5 needs a clear positive instance. A 3 needs the mixed or inconsistent pattern. A 1 or 2 needs what happened instead, a counterexample, or no qualifying instance. An intention is not evidence.

1. In the last ninety days I have been handed a problem I did not already know how to solve.

EVIDENCE (last ninety days):

SCORE 1-5
2. I work close enough to people who are better than me that I can watch how they think.

EVIDENCE (last ninety days):

SCORE 1-5
3. My work is reviewed by someone who can tell the difference between good and adequate, and who says so directly.

EVIDENCE (last ninety days):

SCORE 1-5
4. The feedback I receive changes what I do next, not just how I feel.

EVIDENCE (last ninety days):

SCORE 1-5
5. I regularly operate at the edge of my competence rather than the comfortable center of it.

EVIDENCE (last ninety days):

SCORE 1-5
6. Looking back six months, the work I do now would have been genuinely hard for me then.

EVIDENCE (last ninety days):

Add the six answers. Density score (out of 30):



Part Two: Optionality

Market portability. Six statements, out of 30.



SCORE 1-5

7. The capability I am building would be valued by an employer in a different industry.

EVIDENCE (last ninety days):

SCORE 1-5

8. I can describe what I do in terms of outcomes, not just my company's internal language.

EVIDENCE (last ninety days):

SCORE 1-5

9. If my role disappeared tomorrow, the capability I built would still be mine to carry.

EVIDENCE (last ninety days):

SCORE 1-5

10. People with the power to hire or advance me, inside or outside my company, can already see what I am good at.

EVIDENCE (last ninety days):

SCORE 1-5

11. What I am learning is a transferable capability rather than a company-specific procedure.

EVIDENCE (last ninety days):

SCORE 1-5

12. I could rebuild a strong position somewhere else within a year.

EVIDENCE (last ninety days):

Add the six answers. Optionality score (out of 30):

If you cannot support a score either way, write your most defensible number and add a question mark: 3?, 4?, 2?. Do not force it downward and do not default to a 3. One or two marked items make the axis provisional; three or more mean you do not have ninety days of evidence on that axis. A finding about the window, not a low score.

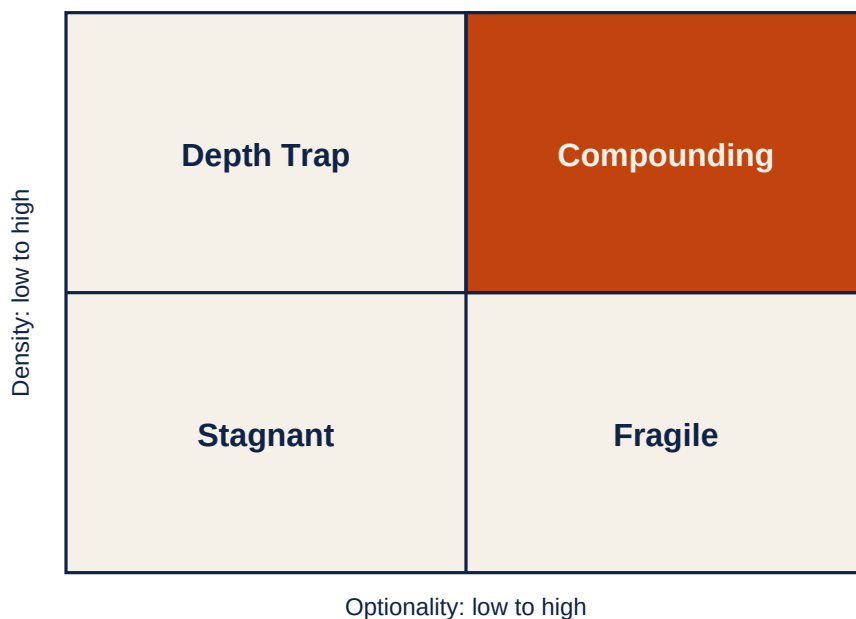
A score without an evidence line is a guess with decimal points.



SECTION 2

Place

Nineteen or higher is high on each axis. Your current state reveals a form of exposure your job title cannot.



- Compounding:** High Density, high Optionality. You are being formed and the market can carry it. The work is protecting it and making sure the right people can see it.
- Depth Trap:** High Density, low Optionality. You are growing, and the growth is trapped where you stand. The work is converting depth into portability.
- Stagnant:** Low Density, low Optionality. Neither the learning nor the portability is moving. The work is restarting learning velocity first.
- Fragile:** Low Density, high Optionality. Mobile on paper, hollowing underneath. The work is stabilizing formation before the mobility gets spent.

The boundary rule: if either score falls between 17 and 21, even a high one, treat yourself as standing on the boundary and read both neighboring states. Small changes matter more near a boundary by construction.

My state today:



The States in the Field



Four anonymized cases from real engagements, one for each state. The patterns are real.

Compounding, read honestly

A senior financial analyst, individual contributor, six years across two firms in global life sciences. Current skills, work reviewed by people who could tell good from adequate, capability that traveled across functions. The audit placed them squarely in Compounding, and their first reaction was that it had nothing to tell them. It did: colleagues with thinner capability had moved past them twice, because work that never gets translated into outcomes leaves the organization to decide on its own what it is worth. The translation came first, then a promotion case built on documented scope. The next cycle brought a formal promotion, and the pay adjustment came with it.

Stagnant, read honestly

A senior director, twelve years at the same firm. Promoted consistently, strong reviews every cycle, and no genuinely new problem in four years. The audit placed them Stagnant: stable, well regarded, and quietly losing the optionality built a decade earlier. The first stretch assignment stalled when its sponsor left. The second moved the number: two quarters later they led a cross-functional initiative that had not existed before. Slower than they wanted, and real.

Depth Trap, read honestly

A Big Four principal, nine years in one practice area. The most technically capable person in the room, and invisible everywhere else. When restructuring compressed the practice, they could not describe what they did outside the methodology's own language. A translation exercise and ninety days of deliberate visibility produced three external conversations in a market that had not seen them in five years, and then a broader role at a firm that recruited them for judgment they had always had but never made legible.

Fragile, read honestly

A VP of operations, three roles in four years. Every move a step up, and none of it compounding: high optionality, real momentum, breadth without the depth that makes breadth hold under pressure. The market kept rewarding the pattern, which is exactly why it stayed invisible. The next move was chosen for the density it would produce rather than the title it carried. Eighteen months in, they called it the first role that was making them more capable instead of merely deploying what they already had.

Four states, one common fact: the number was a map, and the move it pointed to worked. Full cases live at temidayoafonja.com/case-studies.

Whatever your state reads today, someone has stood in it and moved. Read yours the same way: as a starting point.



SECTION 3

Calibrate

Self-scores fail in three characteristic ways. Run all three checks before you accept your numbers.



The Three Misreadings

Worked examples: how the score goes wrong, and how to correct it



Misreading one: scoring the intended life

HOW IT GETS SCORED

"I'm about to lead the new data migration, so statement 1 gets a 5."

HOW IT SHOULD BE SCORED

"In the last ninety days nobody handed me a problem I couldn't already solve. Statement 1 scores a 2. The migration counts when it happens."

Misreading two: confusing being valued with being formed

HOW IT GETS SCORED

"The whole region calls me when the system breaks. I'm essential here. Statement 5 gets a 5."

HOW IT SHOULD BE SCORED

"Being called for what I already know is the comfortable center, not the edge. Essential and stretched are different facts. Statement 5 scores a 2."

Misreading three: reading low Optionality as a verdict on ability

HOW IT GETS SCORED

"My Optionality is 14. I'm clearly not good enough to move."

HOW IT SHOULD BE SCORED

"My Optionality is 14. A low Optionality score may reflect context-bound capability, weak translation, limited exposure, or a combination. It is not a verdict on my ability or worth. The score tells me what to investigate."

The diagnostic asks about the ninety days you lived, the formation you received, and the exposure you carry. Nothing else.

The Rescore Note

What the three checks changed



Run the three misreadings against your twelve scores before you accept them. Where a score does not survive the check, change it and write why. A score you defended and kept is a finding too, so record those as well.

Statements I rescored after calibration, and why:

Self-honesty has a ceiling. The three checks raise it. They do not remove it.

If you want something to argue with your numbers, the Self-Calibration Prompt is in the appendix. It is optional.



SECTION 4

The Room

Eighteen years of closed-door talent reviews, reduced to what you can actually use.



What Gets Weighed When the Doors Close

The performance rating rarely decides the outcome



When a development list, a promotion slate, or a restructuring list is on the table, the conversation runs on a handful of questions. None of them appear in your review form.

How hard would this person be to replace?

The room weighs your formation, not your effort. Deep, current, hard-won capability takes years to rebuild, and everyone at that table knows it.

Who outside this person's manager can vouch for the work?

A single internal sponsor is a single point of failure. Capability that several decision-makers have seen directly weighs more than a rating any one of them assigned.

Is this capability current, or was it current?

Learning velocity is visible from the inside. A talent review can tell the difference between someone absorbing what AI is doing to the function and someone coasting on what they mastered five years ago.

Does this person's value travel, or does it only work here?

Portable capability paradoxically makes you more protected inside, because the room knows you have somewhere to go. Trapped capability invites harder bargains.

These are questions institutional rooms often weigh. Density and Optionality help you read the formation and portability questions underneath them. The diagnostic you just scored runs that reading on yourself first.

The room reads your position whether or not you have. The only choice is who reads it first.



Position Exposure Signals

Questions to investigate, not predictions

SECTION 4, CONTINUED



None of these signals means a decision has been made about you, and none of them predicts one. They identify questions that should be answered before you treat a position as secure.

- Your function starts appearing in vendor demos and AI pilot decks, described as a workflow rather than a team.
- A hiring freeze arrives with exceptions, and the exceptions are not in your area.
- Process documentation suddenly matters: you are asked to write down how you do what you do, with unusual urgency.
- Roles adjacent to yours get consolidated elsewhere in the org, described as efficiency rather than strategy.
- Budget planning cycles shorten, and skip-level leaders take new interest in headcount detail they used to delegate.
- The projects that stretch people quietly migrate to another team, and what remains for yours is maintenance.

What to do with a signal: nothing dramatic. Rescore. A Compounding position reads these signals as noise. A Fragile or Stagnant one reads them as a clock. Either way, the diagnostic tells you which, and the move stays yours to decide.

Prepare before someone decides for you. That is the entire reason this kit exists.



SECTION 5

Standing Still

Staying put is a decision too, and it is not a free one. This section shows what it quietly takes from you.



The Standing-Still Worksheet

What one more quarter in your current state takes from you



Put words, and rough numbers where they fit, on three lines. Estimates are fine; the point is that something concrete exists where a vague unease used to be. A worked example first, for a Depth Trap during an AI rollout:

- The learning gap: the system I am deep in is being wrapped by AI tooling, and the market skill is now the tooling. Another quarter of waiting puts me a full hiring cycle behind: call it three extra months of searching if I ever have to.
- The translation gap: my results live in internal language, and the longer they stay untranslated the harder they are to explain outside. Every quarter of that weakens my footing in any pay conversation.
- The exposure: if the rollout consolidates my function, my Optionality score (14) helps shape how soft the landing is. Realistically, two to four months of income at risk.

Now yours:

The learning gap: what is my learning velocity not keeping up with, and what does another quarter of that gap look like?

The translation gap: what stays untranslated and unseen for another quarter, and what does that do to my footing?

The exposure: if my current state met a restructuring this quarter, what would the landing look like, in months or dollars?

What one more quarter of standing still takes from me, in one line:

Once it has words and a number, standing still stops being background anxiety and becomes a choice you are making.



SECTION 6

The Self-Read

Your position on one page, written in your own hand, with an honest note about its limit.



The Self-Read Skeleton

The same skeleton I use. Fill every line.



My quadrant, and the two scores that put me there:

The strongest evidence lines behind my placement (from Section 1):

My weakest axis, and the single lowest-scoring statement on it:

The misreading I am most likely committing, and what the calibration changed:

The direction a move plan would take from this state (direction only, not the plan):

Date of this read, and the date of my next rescore:

The honest note: this read cannot correct its own author. Self-assessment has a structural limitation: the same person is supplying both the evidence and the judgment. That does not make it useless. It means the reading needs a disciplined correction process. A calibrated read exists for exactly this reason. That is what the live Capability Position Read does: you score, you are corrected against evidence, and you score again.



The Position Card

My position, one card, dated. Print it or screenshot it.



Date of this read:

Density (of 30):

Optionality (of 30):

My state:

Depth Trap	Compounding
Stagnant	Fragile

Mark your square.

My weakest axis, and its lowest-scoring statement:

What one more quarter of standing still takes, in one line (from Section 5):

Date of my next rescore:

Diagnosis only. What to do about it is a different conversation, and it is not on this card.

One page, four fields that matter: the date, the two numbers, and the state. Everything else in this kit exists to make these four honest.



SECTION 7

The Quarterly Loop

Diagnosis once is a snapshot. Diagnosis every ninety days is a position you are managing.



The Rescore Tracker

Four steps, four quarters, one moving picture



1

Rescore

All twelve statements, against the new ninety days, evidence lines included.

2

Compare

Statement by statement, not just totals. One moved statement is the story.

3

Re-place

New position on the matrix, boundary states read if you are near a line.

4

Reset

One line on what another quarter would take, and the date of the next rescore.

The year, tracked:

Date	Density	Optionality	State	What waiting takes, one line

Rescore even in good quarters, especially in good quarters. Compounding is not a permanent address; it is a position that gets protected or gets spent.

Your position becomes something you track instead of something that happens to you.

Where the Kit Ends

This kit ends where diagnosis ends. You now hold your scores, your state, your calibration, your standing-still line, and your self-read. What it deliberately does not contain is a move plan, or any answer to the question of what you should do.

If some of your scores were hard to defend, the kit was working. A self-diagnosis can tell you where you stand. It cannot correct its own miscalibration, and it cannot decide your move.

Both belong in other hands: a live calibration, where you are corrected against evidence rather than against yourself. That is what the Capability Position Read does.

Until then, run the loop. A rescored quarter is worth more than a rushed next step.

You have read your position. The move is the next conversation.

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Appendix: The Self-Calibration Prompt



Put an interrogator between you and your numbers

This appendix is optional. Nothing else in the kit requires an AI assistant, and a read completed without one is complete.

If you use it, notice where the text goes. Your scores leave your control the moment you paste them, and the system on the other side may retain them. Paste numbers and evidence you would be comfortable having stored. Keep out your employer's name, your colleagues' names, and anything you hold in confidence.

What this prompt does is keep asking for evidence after you have stopped asking yourself. That is useful and it is not calibration. It cannot correct its own author any more than you can, and it is built not to advise you. Judgment stays human.

Instructions: fill your twelve scores into the second paragraph, then copy this entire block, statements included, into your AI assistant.

I have scored the twelve-statement diagnostic from The Capability Audit, each statement 1 (strongly disagree) to 5 (strongly agree), against the last ninety days of my actual working life.

My scores. Density: S1 __, S2 __, S3 __, S4 __, S5 __, S6 __, total __ of 30. Optionality: S7 __, S8 __, S9 __, S10 __, S11 __, S12 __, total __ of 30.

The twelve statements, for reference: 1. In the last ninety days I have been handed a problem I did not already know how to solve. 2. I work close enough to people who are better than me that I can watch how they think. 3. My work is reviewed by someone who can tell the difference between good and adequate, and who says so directly. 4. The feedback I receive changes what I do next, not just how I feel. 5. I regularly operate at the edge of my competence rather than the comfortable center of it. 6. Looking back six months, the work I do now would have been genuinely hard for me then. 7. The capability I am building would be valued by an employer in a different industry. 8. I can describe what I do in terms of outcomes, not just my company's internal language. 9. If my role disappeared tomorrow, the capability I built would still be mine to carry. 10. People with the power to hire or advance me, inside or outside my company, can already see what I am good at. 11. What I am learning is a transferable capability rather than a company-specific procedure. 12. I could rebuild a strong position somewhere else within a year.

Before I accept these numbers, interrogate them. Ask me, one at a time, for the specific evidence from the last ninety days behind my three highest answers and my three lowest. If scores tie, choose any three from each end. Challenge any answer where my evidence describes an intention, a plan, or a feeling of being needed rather than a fact of being stretched. Watch for three failure patterns: scoring the life I intend to live instead of the one I lived, confusing being valued by my environment with being formed by it, and treating a low score as a verdict on my ability instead of a fact about my exposure. Do not advise me on what to do next. Do not suggest career moves. Your only job is to test whether my scores survive contact with my actual ninety days, and to tell me which specific statements to rescore and why.